

Tempo

The speed at which music is played, or asked to be played, is known as tempo. There are two main ways of indicating the tempo on a score—by using descriptive words, or using a metronome mark.

A rhythm may be fast or slow

If we look at a rhythm, as shown below, the note values in themselves do not say anything about the tempo. The rhythm could be played fast or slow, or somewhere in between. We need more information to know what tempo to use.



SEE ALSO

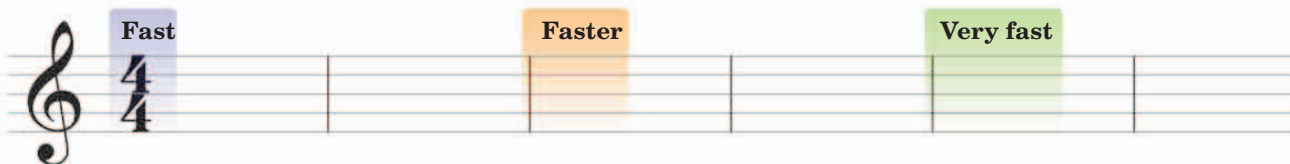
◀ 26–27	Note values
◀ 30–31	Time signatures
Musical expression	104–105 ▶
What is the score?	194–195 ▶

▽ Note values are relative

The information we get from note values concerns their duration in relation to each other. The underlying quarter note beat in this example may be fast or slow.

Indicating tempo

The tempo indicates how fast, or slow, the music should go and is usually marked at the beginning of a piece, above the time signature, and at any place in the music where the tempo changes. One really simple, though imprecise, way is to use words as a direct instruction to the player, as shown below.



▽ Using words

Words can be used to indicate the desired tempo. One may use English words like “fast” or “very fast,” or their Italian equivalents such as “allegro” or “presto.”

GLOSSARY

Words for tempo

It is perfectly normal for composers to use their own language, for instance English, to indicate the tempo. However, it is conventional in music to use Italian terms that musicians understand. Shown here are some of these common terms, though there are plenty more. It is helpful for performers to have a small music dictionary to explain any obscure terms they encounter.

Presto
Allegro
Moderato
Andante
Adagio
Lento



△ Italian tempo terms

Here are six of the most common terms, arranged from the fastest at the top to the slowest at the bottom.

Accelerando
Più mosso
Stringendo (pressing on)
Ritenuto (holding back)
Ritardando
Rallentando



△ Gradual changes

These terms are sometimes followed by a row of dashes, showing how far in the music they apply.